

Life is uncertain, but sport isn't

Sport is **keeping us sane**, or at least giving us the necessary distance from the unpalatable stuff.

Suresh Menon

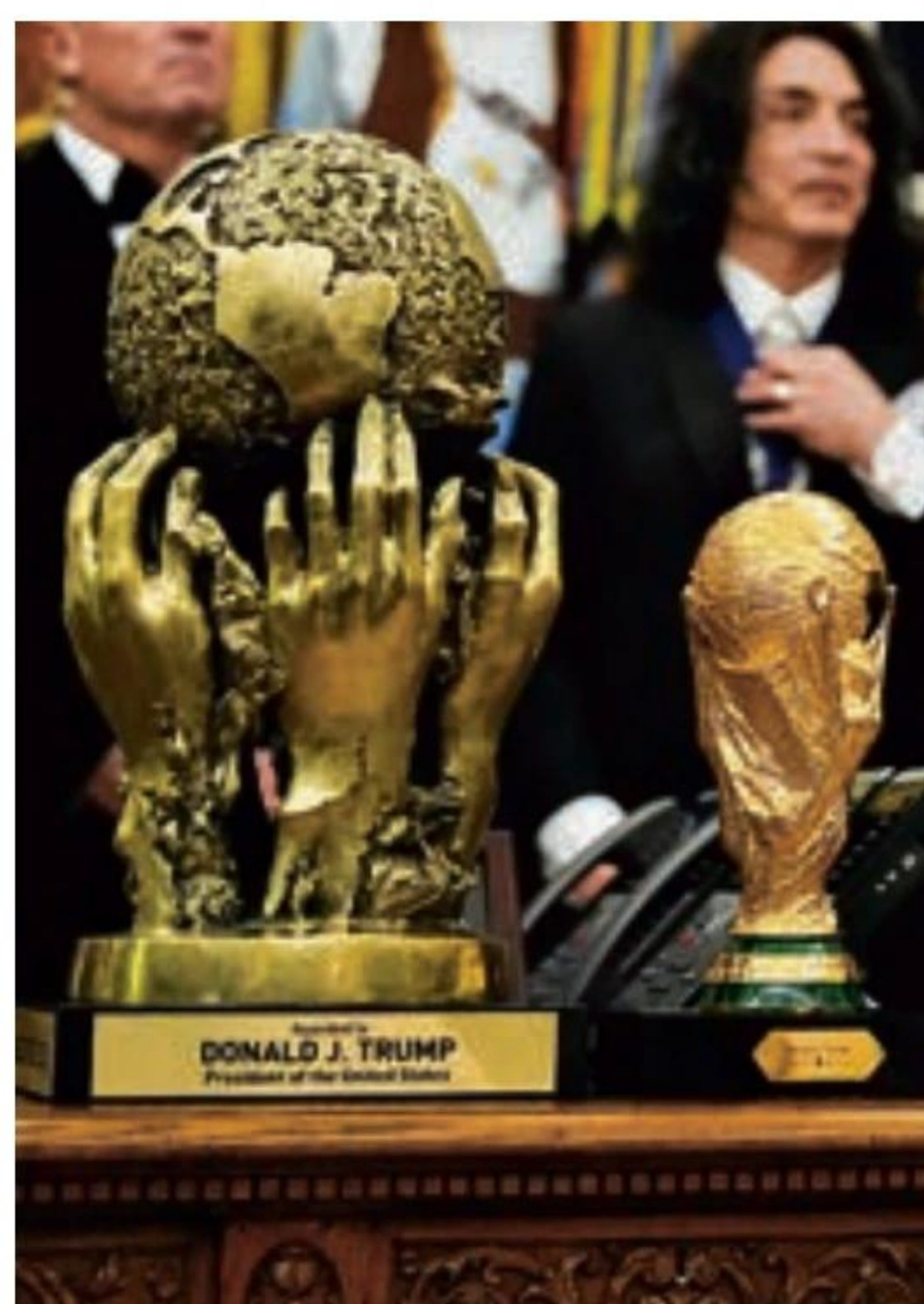
When I was young, and yet to make up my mind whether to win the Nobel Prize for physics or medicine, I felt sport was trivial and real life was serious. Now it seems to be the other way around — real life is becoming more absurd, and the only truth is sport, where you can't claim to have scored a goal in a World Cup or won Wimbledon if you didn't. India won the 2011 cricket World Cup for all time, you can't alter that.

Sport is keeping us sane, or at least giving us the necessary distance from the unpalatable stuff (except when India plays Pakistan, but that's another story).

U.S. President Donald Trump hasn't been given the credit he deserves for this change. The FIFA Peace Prize (**in pic**) has gone to the most deserving candidate after all. Trump has ensured that the only truth is sport.

World Cup football and the Olympics follow each other just as inevitably as the French Open follows the Australian Open in tennis. This is important, for we deal in uncertainty in other areas of our life — health, finance, politics — while craving for certainty. And sport provides that; not with the results of individual competitions but through the events occurring in a pattern.

Baron Pierre de Coubertin, the founder of the modern Olympic Games, described sport in these terms: *O Sport, you are beauty! You create harmony, you fill movement with rhythm, you make strength gracious, and you lend*



power to supple things.

Even if you dismiss that as exaggeration or poetic license, what is important is not whether it is true, but that we would like it to be. The great champion is in control of the physical, mental and spiritual aspects of himself. We may not be in control as individuals, but as a race we are, and that's consolation enough.

The strength of sport lies in its pointlessness, but if you go deep enough everything can be seen as pointless and merely parts of stories we tell ourselves in our search for meaning. We don't know the answers to the Big Questions: Why is there something rather than nothing? Why are we here? So we create a system where we know the

answers, as in the artificial rules of sport. Anybody who plays tennis or any other sport knows what the limits of their game are.

Sport allows us to deal in controlled uncertainties — will that goal be scored? — and in doing so acknowledges at least some of the uncertainties built into our lives.

We love, we create, we pay our taxes, and suddenly Covid hits us and for weeks and months we are at the mercy of a tiny virus that can't be seen with the naked eye. Life is uncertain, but sport is not, and we are grateful for that.

In the post-truth world, sport has a veracity that cannot be twisted to suit anyone's convenience. Rather like gravity, a scoreline endures whether you believe it or not.